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Pritzker OKs \$56B state budget

Spending plan factors in gains from gas sales tax, election-year breaks, but stadium questions loom

By Olivia Olander
and Jeremy Gorner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Decrying federal “headwinds” and drawing a contrast to the gridlock of past state administrations, Gov. JB Pritzker on Tuesday gave his approval to a nearly \$56 billion spending plan that factored in both a windfall from the state’s gas sales tax and a number of election-year tax breaks.

“This is a budget for Illinois’ future, even as the federal government works to take us backward. We won’t go back,” Pritzker said during a signing event at the state’s Chicago headquarters in the West Loop.

Taking effect July 1, the budget covers the last six months of Pritzker’s current term as he seeks reelection to a rare third term and faces questions about a potential 2028 presidential run. It also comes

as the most widely discussed issue from Springfield’s spring legislative session this year, with the effort to incentivize a new stadium for the Chicago Bears remaining unresolved.

Reflecting the haste with which the ruling Democrats muscled their budget through the General Assembly in an all-nighter ending just before dawn on June 1, Pritzker had to use his veto pen to cut more than \$500 billion in approved spending — nearly 10 times the state’s entire operating budget — “due in large

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Right: Gov. JB Pritzker signs Illinois’ budget in Chicago on Tuesday. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



Jacob Potashnick of Feld poses for a photo after winning in the Best Chef: Great Lakes category at the 2026 James Beard Awards at the Lyric Opera House on Monday in Chicago. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

‘THIS IS A CHILDHOOD DREAM COME TRUE’

Chef, owner of Feld was Chicago’s sole winner at 2026 James Beard Restaurant and Chef Awards

By Zareen Syed
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

At the 2026 James Beard Restaurant and Chef Awards, the highest culinary honors in the United States, Jacob Potashnick, chef and owner of Feld, was the city’s sole winner at Monday night’s ceremony at Lyric Opera. “This is a childhood dream come true ... never in my wildest dreams,” Potashnick said moments after he was announced the winner in the Best Chef: Great Lakes category. “I’ve often said that Feld is a restaurant where I tell other people’s stories and

INSIDE: Chicago journalist wins James Beard 2026 Media Award with a story about legendary bean pie. **Food & Health**

that’s down to the chopsticks, not just the food — it’s the tableware and the paintings. It’s so important that people understand that it’s a restaurant that’s special because we are sharing other people’s stories.”

Potashnick, 33, said he set out to create a restaurant driven by the produce and product coming from growers, dairy farmers, fishermen and ranchers. That

relationship with Feld’s carefully sourced network of purveyors is directly translated onto a plate, where courses can be tiny, from a teeny teacup of hot chicken broth infused with an aged Alpine cheese from Pleasant Ridge Reserve, to a small serving of smoked sunchokes or a bean-to-bar chocolate mousse. The kitchen and its ever-evolving menu are unique, Potashnick said, and it’s a testament to his team that it somehow works.

“I always bring it back to the team because every one of these recognitions doesn’t allow just me to call my mom and go ‘we did it,’

but it allows my team to call their moms and say ‘we did it!’” he said. “But if our guests don’t like their meal, none of this matters. What matters is every day we come in grounded and ready to put in the work and be our best.”

The ceremony, hosted by “Top Chef” judge, author and producer Gail Simmons, marked a major milestone with the James Beard Foundation’s 40th anniversary. Celebrity chefs and TV personalities presented the most prestigious awards in the U.S. restaurant industry, filling the gaps with

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Dispute could sink peace agreement

Iran’s call for Israel to withdraw troops in Lebanon adds hurdle

By Jon Gambrell, Sam Metz
and Samy Magdy
ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI, United Arab Emirates — Iran’s top diplomat said Tuesday that the tentative deal to end the war with the United States would require Israel to withdraw from Lebanon — a condition Israel has already rejected and that could sink the agreement, leading to the resumption of all-out war.

The deal, which is between the U.S. and Iran, has not been made public, and officials have sometimes offered contradictory interpretations of what is in it. While Israel is not party to the agreement, it is part of the war: It joined the U.S. in launching strikes on Iran on Feb. 28, and has since fought the Iran-backed Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon and seized large swaths of that country.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said Israel’s continued occupation of southern Lebanon would violate the deal.

“Without the withdrawal of Israeli forces from the territories they occupied during this war, the war has not fully come to an end,” Araghchi said.

A U.S. official, who spoke on condition of anonymity, has said the deal does not call for an Israeli withdrawal.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Monday that Israel would remain in Lebanon “as long as necessary.”

The negotiations to end the war have been plagued by such disagreements before, leading to a prolonged but uneasy ceasefire that has failed to develop into a permanent end to hostilities and has left the Strait of Hormuz, a crucial waterway for the world’s energy supplies, effectively

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OBAMA PRESIDENTIAL CENTER

Political button collectors find new home for their obsession

By A.D. Quig
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

At the new Obama Presidential Center museum — between the former first lady’s gowns and the exhibits about how the former president tackled the wars in Iraq and Afghanistan, the financial crisis and healthcare reform — sits a display fit for some of the country’s most die-hard obsessives: political button collectors.

A political button preoccupation can start almost anywhere, from an initial interest in rare coins to a recognition of a famil-

iar political name or a parent who is a history buff. Then a casual dig through an estate sale bin morphs into obsession, resulting in making bids at auctions, combing through the recesses of eBay or imploring friends in politics to snag you a piece. The most hardcore literally join the club — the American Political Items Collectors.

Few know the grip of that obsession like Ted Hake. His career started by accident. Hake’s mother liked antiques. When a friend opened up a barn full of furniture

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Christen Carter, founder of the Button Museum and owner of the Busy Beaver Button Co., with some of the buttons in the museum on Tuesday in Chicago. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Opening ceremony to feature Wonder, Hudson, Springsteen

Just ahead of the Juneteenth opening of the Obama Presidential Center, former President Barack Obama and first lady Michelle Obama gathered nearly 500 supporters and contributors to the campus for a thank-you celebration on Tuesday. The foundation also announced the lineup for Thursday’s dedication ceremony, which will be livestreamed at 11 a.m. Thursday at obama.org and the foundation’s social media pages. Among the planned performances: Stevie Wonder, Bruce Springsteen and Jennifer Hudson. **Page A6**

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